vibes

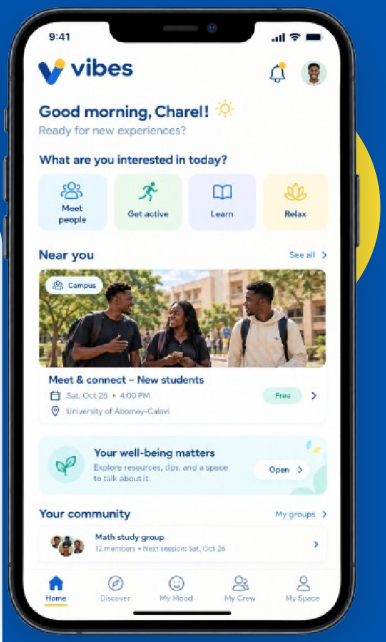
Application
Innovation Challenge 2026

STUDENT WELL-BEING · BENIN

Makes lives happen.

A light app, built by young people for young people, that helps university students put the phone down and find their people, their pace and their habits, in real life.





Team VIBES · UNSTIM, Abomey, Benin
Three students

Submitted to

Education Training Research etr.

YTH LIVE GLOBAL 2026

AT A GLANCE

One idea, in one page.

Imagine a generation that puts the phone down, not out of obligation, but because something better is waiting outside. **VIBES is the first step toward that world.**

1 The problem

Students lose hours to the scroll. Nothing as attractive waits outside, and few dare to say what they need. A very connected generation, and a very lonely one.

2 The people

Students of UNSTIM first (Université Nationale des Sciences, Technologies, Ingénierie et Mathématiques d'Abomey), then other campuses in Benin. Priority: those with no one to go with, who live far from activities, newcomers, and anyone who hesitates to show up alone.

3 The idea

A lightweight web app with three gestures: **Discover** shared passions and activities, **Equip** yourself with a private space, tips and one-tap access to real listening, **Anchor** small habits.

4 The value

A first step that is easier: find a small group, know the real cost before going, take a private moment, and reach trusted contacts or a free helpline in one tap when it is too much.

5 The difference

Most apps win when you stay. VIBES wins when you leave. Success is measured in **lived hours**, not screen time.

6 The plan

We build the MVP ourselves. The award funds what comes next: wider surveys, a youth-led awareness campaign, a supervised pilot and a safe foundation.

3
months of design work led by students

5
dimensions of well-being: social, physical, emotional, mental, food

99
students answered our survey, plus 10 mockup screens and a Design System v1

Survey: 99 students (page 3), a convenience sample. It is a signal, not proof; interviews and mockup tests come next.



Makes lives happen.

THE CHALLENGE

The scroll became their only option.

Our observation on campus is not "young people scroll too much". It is that **nobody helps them listen to themselves**, and nothing as appealing waits outside. Four layers, from the most visible to the deepest:

1 Attraction

Scrolling is designed to hold you; staying is not a lack of willpower. Some of it is also work. We are not against the phone.

2 The void

When the phone goes down, they do not know what to do that is as good, or with whom. So they go back.

3 The silence

Young people know what they need: talk, move, meet, create. What is missing is a place to admit it without being judged.

4 The invisible

Well-being tools exist, but many students do not know them. And when isolation sets in, real listening gets harder to reach, for example in harassment or a health problem.

What adults often misunderstand. They see a lack of willpower. We observe a lack of alternatives and of people to turn to: when screens isolate, it also becomes harder to find a real listening ear. That is why VIBES plans trusted contacts and free helplines one tap away.

WHAT THE DATA SAYS

1 in 6
people worldwide is affected by loneliness (WHO, 2025)

17–21%
of people aged 13 to 29 report feeling lonely (WHO, 2025)

73%
of the 93 students who answered spend 4 hours or more a day on their phone; 29% spend more than 6 hours (our survey)

55.9% of 766 students of the Faculty of Health Sciences in Cotonou showed depressive disorders in a published study. *One faculty, one condition: a real subject, not a figure for all students.*

OUR SURVEY: 99 STUDENTS, UNSTIM SCHOOLS ENSGMM, ENSTP, ENSGEP AND OTHERS

- **48%** (43 of 90) say their phone time is too long for them
- **22%** (20 of 90) would spend nothing on a group activity; 71% at most 1,000 FCFA
- Interest in VIBES: **60% yes** (53), 29% maybe (26), 11% no (10), of 89 answers
- **28%** (25 of 90) often or very often lack company; 58% at least sometimes
- **19%** (18 of 94) have irregular or no personal internet access; 34% with a limited plan too
- **9%** (8 of 92) live in unstable or temporary housing

What it does not show: a convenience sample, self-reported through a form, with some questions left blank. It cannot tell us how all students feel, nor whether VIBES will change anything. It shapes what we build; interviews and a larger, more varied survey are the first uses of the award.

Sources: WHO, 30 June 2025; Klikpo et al., Health Sciences and Disease, 2020. Survey: team data, n = 99 (answers per question: 89 to 94).

OUR RESPONSE

Three gestures. Another way to live campus life.

VIBES is prevention, designed by students. We test every feature with one question: **did the young person spend less time on the screen and more in real life?**

Discover

Find young people who share your passions: football, music, anime, photography, choir. Join events, clubs, or a small **Crew** so the first time is never alone.

Equip

My Safe Place: a private space to note your mood and receive small, practical gestures. **Tips VIBES**: short cards written by young Beninese people, in their words.

Anchor

Small **Sparks** instead of pressure: a walk, a message to a classmate, a screen-free break. No streaks, no rankings, no guilt.

WELL-BEING IN FIVE DIMENSIONS

Social · Physical · Emotional · Mental · Food

Activities are the means, not the goal. The goal: a young person who feels less alone, more energetic and more confident, with the habit of taking care of themselves.

OUR VISION

A student arrives in an unfamiliar city. Within days they have found young people who share their passions, a group to play football with, and a place to say how they are. They feel at home. And this well-being depends neither on their money, nor their contacts, nor luck.



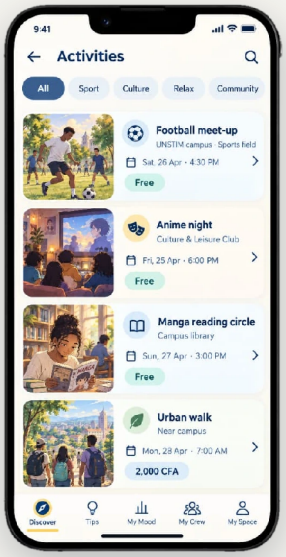
A language of our own

"Let's VIBES" replaces "Let's go out". The vocabulary will be tested with young people before it is adopted. Everything written in the app is drafted and polished by a youth editorial committee.

THE EXPERIENCE

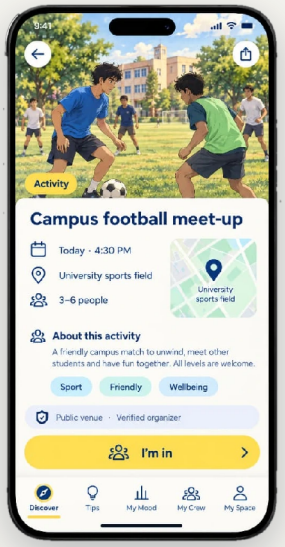
Made for the real moments of student life.

Technology opens the door. Experiences are lived outside.



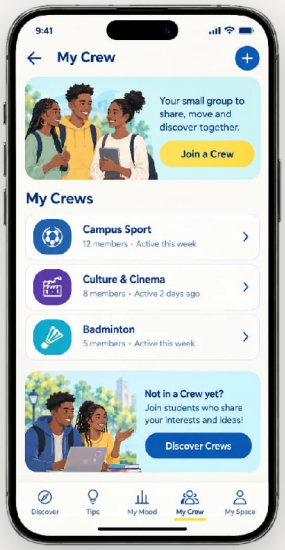
Discover activities

Filter by day, free or nearby. Date, place and cost shown up front.



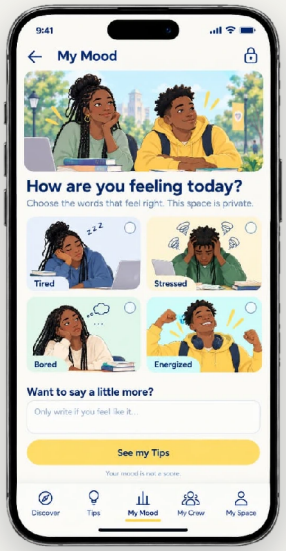
Join with confidence

Practical info first: public venue, free, all levels welcome.



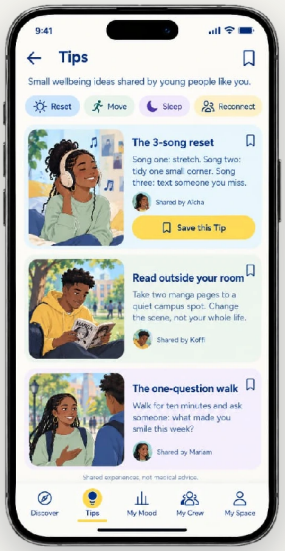
Go with a Crew

A small group around an activity. A chat only for people signed up, no private messages.



Take a moment

My Mood: optional, private, no score, no diagnosis.



Tips VIBES

Short tips shared by young people. Health content is planned to be reviewed by professionals.

How it plays out

1. You spot an activity that speaks to you.
2. You join a small group to get organised.
3. You meet up in person, for real.

Screens are working mockups, subject to change; the first web MVP is being built. **The mockups and the illustrations inside them were generated with AI tools** (we have no designer yet) and are shown in English for this application; the app will be French first.

WHAT SETS US APART

A platform that wins when you leave it.

OUR CENTRAL INDICATOR

Lived hours

The real hours of matches, walks, choir rehearsals and creating that VIBES helped trigger; after each activity, the organiser confirms attendance and each student answers “Did you go thanks to VIBES?”. App time is only a warning signal.

What we do differently

- Answer all four layers, not only the screen
- A place to tell the truth, without judgment
- A small group removes the fear of coming alone
- Real cost, distance and data use shown before you commit

HOW WE COMPARE

Solution	What it does	How VIBES differs
ChillChezCharlee France	Mobile app: you share a weekend wish and it groups 2 to 5 nearby people for a first meeting, then circles of 3 to 6. For students; reporting and verified profiles. Prix Pépite 2025 (its site).	The closest idea, and a sign the need is real. VIBES adds a private well-being space, tips by young Beninese, a Benin context (light web app, cost and distance first) and a different measure: lived hours.
Lynk letslynk.com	Live video platform: timed one-on-one chats, for dating, friends or hosted events.	Online and one-to-one. VIBES is about meeting in person, in small groups, and is not a dating service.
WhatsApp groups and club pages	Already used by clubs to organise.	VIBES builds on them, for students who know no one yet: discovery, a first group, costs up front, help access.

Based on their public websites; we have not tested these products. A wider benchmark in Benin and West Africa is part of the project.

YOUNG PEOPLE LEAD



Adéyinka Laurinda ADANLAO
Team lead · ML Engineer in training & Front-end Developer



Charmel Prosper AFFOUKOU
Systems Thinker and Data Scientist



Judicaël Karol DOBOEVI
Business Development & Product Marketing Manager

Built by young people, for young people: three UNSTIM students in systems thinking, data, business and web development.

How young people shape the idea

The idea comes from what we see around us. We have started checking it with students: a survey of 99 students (page 3), then interviews and mockup tests. App content is planned to be written with a youth editorial committee.

Health content will be reviewed

We come from maths, not health. We plan to ask final-year medical students to review health content. With the award, licensed health professionals will supervise it.

BUILT IN FROM THE DESIGN

Made for here. Safe from the start.

WHO MIGHT BE LEFT OUT, AND OUR ANSWER

Barrier	Our response
Little mobile data, older phone	Lightweight web app, compressed photos, optional SMS or WhatsApp reminders
Tight budget	Filter by real cost, free activities first, shared transport inside the Crew
Far from campus	Distance filter, activities on site
Language	French first, written with young Beninese people; local languages being studied
Shyness, disability, first-generation students	Beginner-friendly activities, accessibility information shown, accompanied first visit

SAFEGUARDS WE ARE DESIGNING IN (PLANNED, NOT YET BUILT)

Activities

Public activities only, in small groups for the first time. Student events will be checked before publication; the most exposed ones will require a public place, daytime hours and posted rules.

Crew chat

Planned: only for people signed up, no private messages, no phone numbers shown, reporting available, closed 48 hours after the event.

Data

We will collect the minimum. No precise location shared between strangers. What you write in My Safe Place stays private. Feelings questions are optional. Photos private by default.

Reliable information

Tips written with young people and reviewed by professionals for health content. Organisers will be verified.

Real listening, one tap away

Isolation makes real listening harder to reach, in harassment or a health problem for example. A "Need help now?" access will stay visible on every screen and point to easy-to-reach trusted contacts and free helplines. Ambassadors will be trained in listening and referral. The whole system will be tested with young people before any wide opening. Still to settle: which local helplines and referral partners we list (we are verifying them; the national 138 line serves children), The pilot is open to ages 18 to 29 only, in line with the challenge.

A clear limit

VIBES is a prevention and well-being initiative. It is not a care service, not a diagnostic tool, not medical or psychological advice, and not a dating app. Our starting rule for notifications: two a day (morning and evening) plus reminders for events you joined, to be tested with students. No challenge on tobacco, alcohol, drugs or betting without a professional, and none on restrictive eating or weight.

THE PLAN

We build first. The award takes it to the next level.

Already here

Design document · Design System v1 · 10 mockup screens · a survey of 99 students

We fund and build ourselves

The lightweight web MVP · interviews and mockup tests with students · first field work on campus

ROADMAP IN MONTHS (TARGETS) · PHASES "WITH THE AWARD" START WHEN FUNDS ARRIVE

Nov – Dec 2026

Listen

In-depth interviews. Mockup tests with 5 to 10 students. Clickable prototype.

Self-funded

Jan – Mar 2027

Build

MVP v1: discover, join, help access. My Mood and Tips after health review. 20 to 30 testers.

Self-funded

Apr – Sep 2027

Prepare

Wider surveys, ambassadors, health review, awareness campaign, hosting (during the holidays).

With the award

Oct – Nov 2027

Pilot

4 to 6 supervised weeks in term, outside exams, ages 18 to 29. Lived hours measured.

With the award

Dec 2027 – Jan 2028

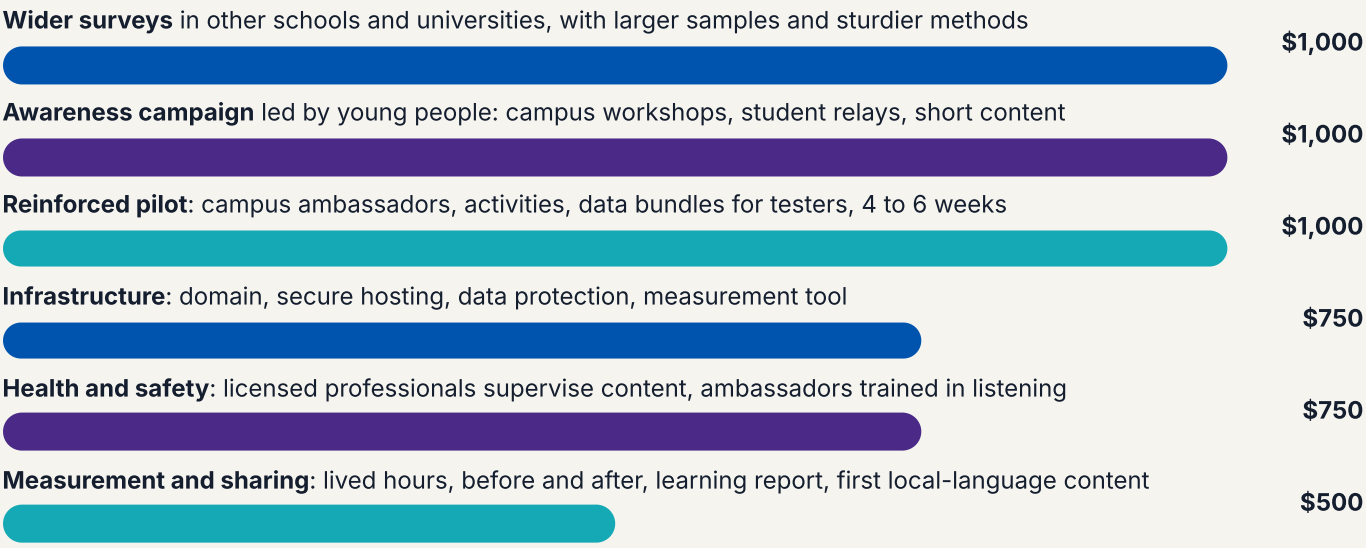
Share

Open learning report. Decision on a second campus and on a mobile app.

With the award

After the award. Beyond January 2028, we will seek in-kind support and co-funding from student federations (FEUA, FEUNSTIM), clubs, our schools and the rectorate, and community partners. None is confirmed yet.

WHAT $5,000 MAKES POSSIBLE (PROPOSED ALLOCATION)



If the award is smaller. At $2,000 or $1,000 we keep the same split and scale the pilot down. The MVP stays self-funded either way.

THE PILOT QUESTION

Do students feel more connected after a few weeks, come back on their own, and take up new habits? We measure with short before/after questions and total lived hours. **No result is claimed yet.**

INDICATORS

Lived hours · self-reported well-being · students who return on their own · real participation · habits installed · accessibility and safety feedback · time in the app (warning signal only).

What we give back to the YTH community. An open learning report (what worked, what did not, anonymised survey data) and a reusable campus kit: survey, activity guide, safety charter, indicators.

From ETR's support and mentorship, we would ask for: safeguarding advice for a youth app (reports, age policy, health content), youth-participatory evaluation, and peer learning with other YTH teams.

Allocation is indicative and will be confirmed with local quotes.

WHY US, WHY NOW

We build before we ask.

We build first. Three months of design work, a survey of 99 students, and an MVP we are building ourselves.
We see the problem up close. We know those screen nights, those empty weekends, and the fear of the first step.

We know how to measure. We say what the data does not prove.
We start from the ground. Our campus, its habits, its WhatsApp groups.
We go against the grain. An app judged by what it gives back.

HOW VIBES ANSWERS THE SELECTION CRITERIA (AS LISTED BY THE CHALLENGE)

Criterion	Our answer	Page
Relevance	A clearly described challenge: student isolation and screen overuse. Four layers, WHO and Benin data, a survey of 99 students	3
Youth leadership	Built by young people, for young people: three students lead; app content planned with a youth editorial committee	6
Usefulness	Users find a small group, know the real cost, take a private moment, build habits and reach trusted help	2, 4, 5
Innovation	Success measured in lived hours, not screen time; a reusable campus kit others can take up	6, 8
Feasibility	Next step: a 4–6 week supervised pilot, funded by the $5,000; the MVP is self-funded	8
Access	Who may be left out: low data, tight budget, distance, language, shyness, disability, first-generation students	7
Safety	Privacy, misinformation (reviewed health content, verified organisers), harm (help access, limits), planned protections	7
Clarity	This application, labelled screens, a clear plan and budget, and a 3 to 5 minute video	2, 5, 8

What if the next good thing started here?

Let's VIBES
vibes-bj.vercel.app
prosperaffoukou@outlook.com

Photos (real, not AI): Iwaria Inc and Muhammad-Taha Ibrahim via Unsplash. Sources: WHO, 30 June 2025 (who.int); Klikpo T. et al., Health Sciences and Disease, 2020 (doi 10.5281/hsd.v21i1.1753). Competitors: public websites of ChillChezCharlee and Lynk. Screens are mockups subject to change.